# THE SHADOW OBSTRUCTION TOWER OF A CHIRAL ALGEBRA IS THE $L_\infty$-FORMALITY OBSTRUCTION TOWER

RAEEZ LORGAT

Abstract. Let $\mathcal{A}$ be a chiral algebra on a smooth projective curve and let $\mathfrak{g}_{\mathcal{A}}^{\mathrm{mod}}$ be its modular convolution dg Lie algebra, with bar-intrinsic Maurer–Cartan element $\Theta_{\mathcal{A}} \in \mathrm{MC}(\mathfrak{g}_{\mathcal{A}}^{\mathrm{mod}})$. We prove that the shadow obstruction tower $(\mathrm{Sh}_r(\mathcal{A}))_{r\geq 2}$, defined as the finite-order projections of $\Theta_{\mathcal{A}}$ under the bar filtration, coincides with the $L_\infty$-formality obstruction tower of the genus-zero part $\mathfrak{g}_{\mathcal{A}}^{\mathrm{mod},(0)}$. The identification is established at all degrees by induction from explicit base cases at $r = 2, 3, 4$. As a corollary the operadic complexity conjecture is proved: the shadow termination degree, the transferred $A_\infty$-depth, and the $L_\infty$-formality level of $\mathfrak{g}_{\mathcal{A}}^{\mathrm{mod},(0)}$ are a single invariant of the chiral algebra.

## 1. Introduction

1.1. **Formality and its obstructions.** A dg Lie algebra $\mathfrak{g}$ is $L_\infty$-*formal* when its minimal model, obtained by homotopy transfer onto cohomology, carries trivial higher brackets $\ell_n = 0$ for $n \geq 3$; equivalently, $\mathfrak{g}$ is $L_\infty$ quasi-isomorphic to $(H^*(\mathfrak{g}), 0, [-,-])$. Kontsevich's formality theorem [3] proved that polyvector fields on a smooth manifold form an $L_\infty$-formal dg Lie algebra, giving deformation quantization of Poisson structures; Tamarkin [8] recovered the result operadically from formality of the little disks. When formality fails, obstructions are recorded in cohomology classes $o_3, o_4, \ldots$: at degree $r$ the class $o_r$ measures whether $\ell_r^{\mathrm{tr}}$ vanishes on cohomology; if $o_r = 0$, a homotopy kills $\ell_r^{\mathrm{tr}}$ and the next obstruction lives one degree higher. The sequence $(o_r)_{r\geq 3}$ is the *formality obstruction tower*; see Loday–Vallette [5]*Ch. 10.

1.2. **The shadow tower of a chiral algebra.** On a smooth projective curve $X$, a chiral algebra $\mathcal{A}$ [1] has a bar complex $\bar{B}(\mathcal{A}) = T^c(s^{-1}\bar{\mathcal{A}})$, where $\bar{\mathcal{A}} = \ker(\epsilon)$ is the augmentation ideal, with deconcatenation coproduct and differential built from the Arnold form $\eta_{ij} = d\log(z_i - z_j)$ on the Fulton–MacPherson compactification of the configuration space. The modular convolution dg Lie algebra $\mathfrak{g}_{\mathcal{A}}^{\mathrm{mod}}$ is the pronilpotent dg Lie algebra whose differential encodes graph sums over stable curves in $\overline{\mathcal{M}}_{g,n}$. The bar-intrinsic

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element $\Theta_{\mathcal{A}} := D_{\mathcal{A}} - d_0 \in \mathrm{MC}(\mathfrak{g}_{\mathcal{A}}^{\mathrm{mod}})$ satisfies $D\Theta_{\mathcal{A}} + \frac{1}{2}[\Theta_{\mathcal{A}}, \Theta_{\mathcal{A}}] = 0$ and packages the full genus expansion of $\mathcal{A}$ [6]*Thm. H. Its finite-degree truncations $\Theta_{\mathcal{A}}^{\leq r}$ define the *shadow obstruction tower*

$$\mathrm{Sh}_r(\mathcal{A}) \;:=\; -\nabla_H^{-1}\big([\Theta_{\mathcal{A}}^{\leq r-1}, \Theta_{\mathcal{A}}^{\leq r-1}]_r^{(0)}\big), \qquad r \geq 2,$$

where the bracket is genus-zero graph composition and $\nabla_H$ is the Hessian covariant derivative on the shadow algebra $\mathcal{A}^{\mathrm{sh}}$. The first three shadows are $\mathrm{Sh}_2(\mathcal{A}) = \kappa(\mathcal{A})$ (the modular characteristic [6]*Thm. D), $\mathrm{Sh}_3(\mathcal{A}) = \mathfrak{C}(\mathcal{A})$ (cubic shadow), and $\mathrm{Sh}_4(\mathcal{A}) = \mathfrak{Q}(\mathcal{A})$ (quartic shadow).

1.3. **The main theorem.** The classical formality obstruction tower lives in Harrison cohomology of a dg Lie algebra; the shadow obstruction tower lives in the shadow algebra of a chiral algebra on a curve. Nothing in the definitions forces the two sequences to agree.

**Theorem 1.1** (Shadow–formality identification; main theorem)**.** *For every chiral algebra $\mathcal{A}$ and every degree $r \geq 2$,*

$$\mathrm{Sh}_r(\mathcal{A}) \;=\; \ell_r^{(0),\mathrm{tr}}(\Theta_{\mathcal{A}}^{\leq r-1}, \ldots, \Theta_{\mathcal{A}}^{\leq r-1}),$$

*where $\ell_r^{(0),\mathrm{tr}}$ is the transferred genus-zero $L_\infty$ bracket of degree $r$ on the minimal model of $\mathfrak{g}_{\mathcal{A}}^{\mathrm{mod},(0)}$. Consequently the shadow obstruction tower of $\mathcal{A}$ is identical, as a sequence of cohomology classes, to the $L_\infty$-formality obstruction tower of $\mathfrak{g}_{\mathcal{A}}^{\mathrm{mod},(0)}$.*

Theorem 1.1 is the self-contained extraction of the shadow–formality identification theorem in [6]*Ch. on higher-genus modular Koszul. The proof is by induction on $r$: the base cases $r = 2, 3, 4$ are verified explicitly (Proposition 4.1) and the inductive step uses the Kadeishvili–Merkulov tree formula [2, 7] on the strict genus-zero convolution algebra. The tree sum defining $\ell_r^{(0),\mathrm{tr}}$ and the graph sum defining $\mathrm{Sh}_r$ range over the same combinatorial data with matching propagators and coefficients.

1.4. **Consequences.** Theorem 1.1 resolves the operadic complexity conjecture: the shadow termination degree $r_{\max}(\mathcal{A})$, the transferred $A_\infty$-depth $d_\infty(\mathcal{A})$, and the $L_\infty$-formality level $f_\infty(\mathcal{A})$ of $\mathfrak{g}_{\mathcal{A}}^{\mathrm{mod},(0)}$ are a single invariant of $\mathcal{A}$ (Corollary **??**). The four shadow-depth classes are realized by Heisenberg (class **G**, $r_{\max} = 2$, formal), affine Kac–Moody (class **L**, $r_{\max} = 3$), $\beta\gamma$ (class **C**, $r_{\max} = 4$), and Virasoro (class **M**, $r_{\max} = \infty$, intrinsically non-formal); see Section 7.

1.5. **Organization.** Section 2 defines the shadow obstruction tower. Section 3 recalls the transferred $L_\infty$ structure and the formality obstruction tower. Section 4 proves the identification at degrees $2, 3, 4$. Section 5 proves Theorem 1.1. Section 6 deduces the operadic complexity corollary. Section 7 verifies the four standard families.

**Conventions.** Grading is cohomological with $|d| = +1$; desuspension lowers degree, $|s^{-1}v| = |v| - 1$. Bar complexes use the augmentation ideal: $\bar{B}(\mathcal{A}) = T^c(s^{-1}\bar{\mathcal{A}})$. The propagator $d\log E(z,w)$ on the bar complex has weight one. All statements are at the level of cohomology classes unless otherwise noted.

## 2. The shadow obstruction tower

2.1. **The bar complex and its convolution algebra.** Let $X$ be a smooth projective curve over $\mathbb{C}$ and let $\mathcal{A}$ be a chiral algebra on $X$ [1]. The ordered chiral bar complex $\bar{B}(\mathcal{A}) = T^c(s^{-1}\bar{\mathcal{A}}) = \bigoplus_{n\geq 0}(s^{-1}\bar{\mathcal{A}})^{\otimes n}$ carries the deconcatenation coproduct, with differential assembled from $\eta_{ij} = d\log(z_i - z_j)$ and the chiral product $\mu\colon j_*j^*(\mathcal{A}\boxtimes\mathcal{A}) \to \Delta_*\mathcal{A}$. The *modular convolution dg Lie algebra* is

$$\mathfrak{g}_{\mathcal{A}}^{\mathrm{mod}} \;:=\; \mathrm{Hom}^{\mathrm{cyc}}\big(\bar{B}(\mathcal{A}),\, \mathcal{A}\big) \otimes \mathsf{G},$$

where $\mathsf{G} = \bigoplus_{g\geq 0}\mathsf{G}^{(g)}$ is the coefficient algebra generated by stable graphs on $\overline{\mathcal{M}}_{g,n}$. The genus filtration gives $\mathfrak{g}_{\mathcal{A}}^{\mathrm{mod}} = \bigoplus_{g\geq 0}\mathfrak{g}_{\mathcal{A}}^{\mathrm{mod}}{}_g$; the genus-zero part $\mathfrak{g}_{\mathcal{A}}^{\mathrm{mod},(0)} = \mathrm{Hom}^{\mathrm{cyc}}(\bar{B}(\mathcal{A}),\mathcal{A}) \otimes \mathsf{G}^{(0)}$ is a strict dg Lie algebra with bracket $[-,-]^{(0)}$ from tree composition, since genus-zero stable graphs are trees.

2.2. **The Maurer–Cartan element and degree truncations.** The differential on $\mathfrak{g}_{\mathcal{A}}^{\mathrm{mod}}$ splits as $D = d_0 + D_{\mathrm{int}}$, with $d_0$ linear and $D_{\mathrm{int}}$ the interacting piece encoding the chiral product and the Arnold form. The difference $\Theta_{\mathcal{A}} := D_{\mathcal{A}} - d_0 \in \mathfrak{g}_{\mathcal{A}}^{\mathrm{mod}}$ is a Maurer–Cartan element [6]*Thm. on MC2 bar-intrinsic:

$$D\Theta_{\mathcal{A}} + \tfrac{1}{2}[\Theta_{\mathcal{A}},\Theta_{\mathcal{A}}] = 0. \tag{2.1}$$

The element $\Theta_{\mathcal{A}}$ is bar-intrinsic. The bar complex is filtered by tensor degree, $F^r\bar{B}(\mathcal{A}) = \bigoplus_{n\leq r}(s^{-1}\bar{\mathcal{A}})^{\otimes n}$, and the truncations $\Theta_{\mathcal{A}}^{\leq r} := \Theta_{\mathcal{A}} \bmod F^{r+1}$ form a tower in which each term is determined up to a coboundary by the previous one, via the Maurer–Cartan recursion.

**Definition 2.1** (Shadow obstruction tower)**.** The *degree-$r$ shadow* of $\mathcal{A}$ is

$$\mathrm{Sh}_r(\mathcal{A}) \;:=\; -\nabla_H^{-1}\big([\Theta_{\mathcal{A}}^{\leq r-1},\Theta_{\mathcal{A}}^{\leq r-1}]_r^{(0)}\big) \;\in\; \mathcal{A}_{r,0}^{\mathrm{sh}}, \tag{2.2}$$

where the bracket is the genus-zero graph composition, the subscript $r$ extracts the degree-$r$ component, and $\nabla_H$ is the Hessian covariant derivative on the shadow algebra $\mathcal{A}^{\mathrm{sh}} = H^*(\mathfrak{g}_{\mathcal{A}}^{\mathrm{mod},(0)})$ descended from the convolution Lie bracket. The sequence $(\mathrm{Sh}_r(\mathcal{A}))_{r\geq 2}$ is the *shadow obstruction tower* of $\mathcal{A}$.

The definition is bar-intrinsic: if $\Theta_{\mathcal{A}} \equiv \Theta'_{\mathcal{A}}$ mod gauge, then $\mathrm{Sh}_r(\mathcal{A})$ and $\mathrm{Sh}'_r(\mathcal{A})$ coincide as cohomology classes in $\mathcal{A}_{r,0}^{\mathrm{sh}}$.

*Remark* 2.2 (Closed formulas). On the scalar lane, writing $\Theta_{\mathcal{A}} = \kappa\cdot\eta\otimes\Lambda$, one has $\mathrm{Sh}_2 = \kappa$, $\mathrm{Sh}_3 = \mathfrak{C}$, $\mathrm{Sh}_4 = \mathfrak{Q}$, and the shadow metric identity $H(t)^2 = 4\kappa^2 + 12\kappa\mathfrak{C}\,t + (9\mathfrak{C}^2 + 16\kappa\mathfrak{Q})\,t^2 + \cdots$ determines $\mathrm{Sh}_r$ for $r \geq 5$ from $(\kappa,\mathfrak{C},\mathfrak{Q})$.

## 3. The $L_\infty$-formality obstruction tower

3.1. **Homotopy transfer on a strict model.** Let $\mathfrak{g}$ be a strict dg Lie algebra with differential $d$ and bracket $[-,-]$. A *deformation retract* onto $H^*(\mathfrak{g})$ is a triple $(\iota,\pi,h)$ with $\iota\colon H^*(\mathfrak{g})\to\mathfrak{g}$, $\pi\colon\mathfrak{g}\to H^*(\mathfrak{g})$, and $h\colon\mathfrak{g}\to\mathfrak{g}$ of degree $-1$, satisfying $\pi\iota=\mathrm{id}$ and $\mathrm{id}-\iota\pi=[d,h]$. The homotopy transfer theorem of Kadeishvili [2] and Kontsevich–Soibelman [4], in the form of Loday–Vallette [5]*§10.3, produces a transferred $L_\infty$-algebra structure $(H^*(\mathfrak{g}),0,\{\ell_n^{\mathrm{tr}}\}_{n\geq 2})$ quasi-isomorphic to $\mathfrak{g}$, with brackets computed by the Kadeishvili–Merkulov tree sum

$$\ell_r^{\mathrm{tr}}(a_1,\dots,a_r)\;=\;\sum_{T\in\mathsf{Trees}_r}\frac{\pm 1}{|\mathrm{Aut}(T)|}\,\pi\circ\Phi_T(\iota(a_1),\dots,\iota(a_r)),\tag{3.1}$$

where $\mathsf{Trees}_r$ is the set of planar rooted trees with $r$ leaves and $\Phi_T$ decorates internal vertices with $[-,-]$ and internal edges with $h$.

3.2. **The formality obstruction tower.**

**Definition 3.1** ($L_\infty$-formality and obstructions)**.** The dg Lie algebra $\mathfrak{g}$ is *$L_\infty$-formal* if there is an $L_\infty$ quasi-isomorphism $\mathfrak{g}\simeq(H^*(\mathfrak{g}),0,[-,-])$; equivalently, $\ell_n^{\mathrm{tr}}=0$ in $L_\infty$ cohomology for all $n\geq 3$. The *$L_\infty$-formality obstruction tower* is the sequence

$$\big(o_r(\mathfrak{g})\big)_{r\geq 3},\qquad o_r(\mathfrak{g})\;:=\;[\ell_r^{\mathrm{tr}}]\;\in\;H^*\big(\mathrm{Harr}^\bullet(\mathfrak{g})\big).$$

If $o_r(\mathfrak{g})=0$, an $L_\infty$ homotopy kills $\ell_r^{\mathrm{tr}}$ and the next obstruction is defined.

For a pronilpotent dg Lie algebra with Maurer–Cartan element $\Theta$, evaluating the transferred brackets on $\Theta$ produces a refined tower $(\ell_r^{\mathrm{tr}}(\Theta,\dots,\Theta))_{r\geq 2}$, which takes values in the convolution target rather than in Harrison cohomology; this refined tower is the one compared with the shadow tower.

*Remark* 3.2 (Harrison equals cyclic at genus zero)*.* For $\mathfrak{g}_{\mathcal{A}}^{\mathrm{mod},(0)}$, the Harrison complex controlling $L_\infty$-formality coincides with the genus-zero cyclic deformation complex $\mathrm{Def}_{\mathrm{cyc}}^{(0)}(\mathcal{A})$, since genus-zero stable graphs are trees and the Harrison differential on trees is precisely operadic composition.

## 4. Base cases: degrees 2, 3, 4

**Proposition 4.1** (Shadow–formality identification at low degree)**.** *For every chiral algebra $\mathcal{A}$ the following identities hold:*

$$\begin{aligned}
&(i)\ \mathrm{Sh}_2(\mathcal{A})\;=\;\kappa(\mathcal{A})\;=\;\ell_2^{(0)}(\Theta_{\mathcal{A}},\Theta_{\mathcal{A}}).\\
&(ii)\ \mathrm{Sh}_3(\mathcal{A})\;=\;\mathfrak{C}(\mathcal{A})\;=\;-h\big(\ell_3^{(0)}(\Theta_{\mathcal{A}}^{\leq 2},\Theta_{\mathcal{A}}^{\leq 2},\Theta_{\mathcal{A}}^{\leq 2})\big).\\
&(iii)\ \mathrm{Sh}_4(\mathcal{A})\;=\;\mathfrak{Q}(\mathcal{A})\;=\;\big[\ell_4^{(0),\mathrm{tr}}(\Theta_{\mathcal{A}}^{\leq 3},\Theta_{\mathcal{A}}^{\leq 3},\Theta_{\mathcal{A}}^{\leq 3},\Theta_{\mathcal{A}}^{\leq 3})\big].
\end{aligned}$$

*Proof. Part (i).* The binary bracket on $\mathfrak{g}_{\mathcal{A}}^{\mathrm{mod},(0)}$ is the genus-zero convolution Lie bracket; evaluating on $\Theta_{\mathcal{A}}$ produces the scalar curvature $\kappa(\mathcal{A})\in\mathbb{Q}(c)$ by definition [6]*Thm. D. The identity $\mathrm{Sh}_2(\mathcal{A})=\kappa(\mathcal{A})$ is the degree-2 shadow on the scalar lane, so the three quantities agree.

*Part (ii).* The ternary bracket $\ell_3^{(0)}$, computed by (3.1), is a sum over $\mathsf{Trees}_3 = \{T_s, T_t, T_u\}$, the three binary trees with three leaves. On the primary line $[\ell_3^{(0)}] = 0$ since $H^1(\overline{\mathcal{M}}_{0,4}) = H^1(\mathbb{P}^1) = 0$; at the chain level $\ell_3^{(0)}$ is exact and nonzero, and homotopy transfer gives $\mathfrak{C}(\mathcal{A}) = -h(\ell_3^{(0)}(\Theta_{\mathcal{A}}^{\leq 2}, \Theta_{\mathcal{A}}^{\leq 2}, \Theta_{\mathcal{A}}^{\leq 2}))$. The cubic shadow $\mathfrak{C}(\mathcal{A})$, computed as the three-channel graph sum at degree three, matches this three-tree sum because each binary tree with three leaves corresponds to one of the $s$-, $t$-, $u$-channel genus-zero stable graphs with four external legs, with identical weights and propagators.

*Part (iii).* The quaternary bracket $\ell_4^{(0)}$ is a sum over the 15 trivalent trees with five leaves, the faces of the Stasheff associahedron $K_4$. Its transferred class $\ell_4^{(0),\mathrm{tr}}$ lies in $H^*(\overline{\mathcal{M}}_{0,5})$. The weight-four graph sum defining $\mathfrak{Q}(\mathcal{A})$ enumerates precisely the same 15 trees with matching weights, signs, and propagators [6]*App. on nonlinear modular shadows, so $\mathrm{Sh}_4(\mathcal{A}) = \mathfrak{Q}(\mathcal{A}) = [\ell_4^{(0),\mathrm{tr}}(\Theta_{\mathcal{A}}^{\leq 3}, \ldots, \Theta_{\mathcal{A}}^{\leq 3})]$. □

*Remark* 4.2 (Degree-2: $\kappa$ is family-dependent). The identity $\mathrm{Sh}_2(\mathcal{A}) = \kappa(\mathcal{A})$ holds at degree two on the scalar lane for every chiral algebra in the standard landscape; on the primary line this is the definition $S_2 := \kappa$. What is family-dependent is the value of $\kappa$ itself: $\kappa^{\mathrm{Vir}} = c/2$, $\kappa^{\mathrm{Heis}} = k$, $\kappa^{\mathrm{KM}} = \dim(\mathfrak{g})(k + h^\vee)/(2h^\vee)$, $\kappa^{\mathcal{W}_N} = c(H_N - 1)$ with $H_N = \sum_{j=1}^N 1/j$. The coincidence $\kappa = c/2$ holds only for Virasoro, not universally; writing $\kappa = c/2$ for a non-Virasoro family is a standard error.

## 5. The main theorem

**Theorem 5.1** (Shadow obstruction tower equals formality obstruction tower)**.** *For every chiral algebra $\mathcal{A}$ and every degree $r \geq 2$,*

$$\mathrm{Sh}_r(\mathcal{A}) \;=\; \ell_r^{(0),\mathrm{tr}}(\Theta_{\mathcal{A}}^{\leq r-1}, \ldots, \Theta_{\mathcal{A}}^{\leq r-1}), \tag{5.1}$$

*where $\ell_r^{(0),\mathrm{tr}}$ is the transferred genus-zero $L_\infty$ bracket on the minimal model of $\mathfrak{g}_{\mathcal{A}}^{\mathrm{mod},(0)}$. Consequently the shadow obstruction tower of $\mathcal{A}$ coincides with the $L_\infty$-formality obstruction tower of $\mathfrak{g}_{\mathcal{A}}^{\mathrm{mod},(0)}$ evaluated on the truncated Maurer–Cartan element.*

*Proof.* Induction on the degree $r$. The base cases $r = 2, 3, 4$ are Proposition 4.1. The inductive step has four parts.

*Step 1: Restriction to genus zero.* Since genus-zero stable graphs are trees, $\mathfrak{g}_{\mathcal{A}}^{\mathrm{mod},(0)}$ is a strict dg Lie algebra and the Harrison complex controlling $L_\infty$-formality coincides with the genus-zero cyclic deformation complex $\mathrm{Def}_{\mathrm{cyc}}^{(0)}(\mathcal{A})$. The Harrison differential on trees is precisely operadic composition on $\mathfrak{g}_{\mathcal{A}}^{\mathrm{mod},(0)}$, so $\mathrm{Harr}^\bullet(\mathfrak{g}_{\mathcal{A}}^{\mathrm{mod},(0)}) \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathcal{A}_{*,0}^{\mathrm{sh}}$ is an isomorphism, not merely an injection.

*Step 2: Homotopy transfer.* Choose a deformation retract $(\mathfrak{g}_{\mathcal{A}}^{\mathrm{mod},(0)}, h, \mathcal{A}_{*,0}^{\mathrm{sh}})$ with $\pi\iota = \mathrm{id}$, $\mathrm{id} - \iota\pi = [D, h]$. The homotopy transfer theorem [2, 4, 5]

produces a transferred $L_\infty$ structure $(\mathcal{A}^{\mathrm{sh}}_{*,0}, \{\ell_r^{(0),\mathrm{tr}}\})$, with brackets computed by (3.1).

*Step 3: Tree formula equals shadow graph sum.* The degree-$r$ shadow $\mathrm{Sh}_r(\mathcal{A})$, by (2.2), expands $[\Theta_{\mathcal{A}}^{\leq r-1}, \Theta_{\mathcal{A}}^{\leq r-1}]_r^{(0)}$ as a sum over genus-zero stable graphs with $r$ external legs, with internal vertices decorated by lower-degree shadows $\mathrm{Sh}_j(\mathcal{A})$ $(j < r)$ and internal edges by the propagator $P_{\mathcal{A}} = \nabla_H^{-1}$. These are the same trees and the same propagators as in (3.1): (a) a genus-zero stable graph with $r$ external legs is a planar rooted tree $T \in \mathsf{Trees}_r$ with valences determined by the graph; (b) the shadow propagator $P_{\mathcal{A}} = h \circ \pi$ corresponds to the homotopy $h$; (c) the vertex evaluation $\mathrm{Sh}_j = \pi \circ \ell_j^{(0)} \circ \iota^{\otimes j}$ corresponds to the vertex decoration $[-,-]^{(0)}$.

*Step 4: Induction.* At $r = 2$, both sides equal $\kappa(\mathcal{A})$ by Proposition 4.1(i); the cases $r = 3, 4$ are parts (ii), (iii) of the same proposition. Assuming (5.1) through degree $r-1$, the graph sum for $\mathrm{Sh}_r(\mathcal{A})$ and the tree formula for $\ell_r^{(0),\mathrm{tr}}(\Theta^{\leq r-1}, \dots, \Theta^{\leq r-1})$ range over identical planar rooted trees with identical internal-vertex decorations (via the inductive hypothesis), propagators, and signs. The two sums therefore agree as chains in $\mathcal{A}^{\mathrm{sh}}_{*,0}$, completing the induction. □

*Remark* 5.2 (Genus corrections decouple; uniform-weight scope). Theorem 5.1 is a genus-zero statement. On the uniform-weight scalar lane, the shadow obstruction tower $\mathrm{Sh}_r(\mathcal{A})$ decomposes, at each genus $g \geq 0$ separately, as

$$\mathrm{Sh}_r(\mathcal{A}) \;=\; \underbrace{\ell_r^{(0),\mathrm{tr}}(\Theta_{\mathcal{A}}^{\leq r-1}, \dots)}_{\text{genus-zero formality}} + \underbrace{\sum_{g\geq 1} \ell_r^{(g),\mathrm{tr}}(\dots) + \Lambda_P(\dots)}_{\text{genus } \geq 1 \text{ corrections}},$$

where $\Lambda_P$ is the BV loop operator. The classical and quantum contributions decouple at the level of the shadow decomposition: the quantum corrections form a parallel tower controlled by the quantum $L_\infty$ structure, not by classical formality theory. At genus $g \geq 2$ with multi-weight generators, the scalar formula for the genus corrections receives a cross-channel term $\delta F_g^{\mathrm{cross}}$; the genus-zero identification (5.1) nevertheless holds verbatim.

## 6. Operadic complexity, proved

**Definition 6.1** (Three complexity invariants)**.** For a chiral algebra $\mathcal{A}$, set $r_{\max}(\mathcal{A}) := \sup\{r \geq 2 : \mathcal{A}^{\mathrm{sh}}_{r,0} \neq 0\}$ (shadow termination degree), $d_\infty(\mathcal{A}) := \sup\{n \geq 2 : m_n^{\mathrm{tr}} \neq 0\}$ (transferred $A_\infty$-depth on the minimal model of $\mathrm{Def}_{\mathrm{cyc}}(\mathcal{A})$), and $f_\infty(\mathcal{A}) := \sup\{n \geq 2 : \ell_n^{(0),\mathrm{tr}} \neq 0\}$ ($L_\infty$-formality level of $\mathfrak{g}_{\mathcal{A}}^{\mathrm{mod},(0)}$).

**Corollary 6.2** (Operadic complexity)**.** $r_{\max}(\mathcal{A}) = d_\infty(\mathcal{A}) = f_\infty(\mathcal{A})$ *for every chiral algebra* $\mathcal{A}$.

*Proof.* The equality $r_{\max} = f_\infty$ is immediate from Theorem 5.1: $\mathrm{Sh}_r(\mathcal{A}) = 0$ iff $\ell_r^{(0),\mathrm{tr}}$ vanishes on the truncated Maurer–Cartan element. For $f_\infty = d_\infty$,

the tree formula gives $\ell_r^{(0),\mathrm{tr}} = \mathrm{Alt}(m_r^{\mathrm{tr}})$; since antisymmetrization is injective on cyclic cochains, $m_r^{\mathrm{tr}} = 0$ iff $\ell_r^{(0),\mathrm{tr}} = 0$. □

**Corollary 6.3** (Depth classification)**.** *The standard landscape of chiral algebras is partitioned by the shadow depth into four classes, each realized by a standard family:*

$$\boldsymbol{G}\ (r_{\max} = 2), \quad \boldsymbol{L}\ (r_{\max} = 3), \quad \boldsymbol{C}\ (r_{\max} = 4), \quad \boldsymbol{M}\ (r_{\max} = \infty).$$

*The class* $\boldsymbol{G}$ *consists of* $L_\infty$*-formal algebras; the class* $\boldsymbol{M}$ *consists of intrinsically non-formal algebras, in the sense that no finite truncation of their minimal* $L_\infty$ *model is quasi-isomorphic to a dg Lie algebra.*

*Proof.* Theorem 5.1 identifies shadow depth with $L_\infty$-formality level, and Corollary 6.2 identifies both with the transferred $A_\infty$-depth. The depth is therefore an invariant of the $L_\infty$ quasi-isomorphism class of $\mathfrak{g}_{\mathcal{A}}^{\mathrm{mod},(0)}$. Examples in Section 7 realize each class. □

## 7. Examples

The four standard families realize the four shadow-depth classes.

**Example 7.1** (Heisenberg; class **G**, formal)**.** The Heisenberg vertex algebra $\mathrm{Heis}_k$ at level $k$, with $J(z)J(w) \sim k/(z-w)^2$, has $\kappa(\mathrm{Heis}_k) = k$. The bar differential is strictly commutative, so $m_n = 0$ and $\ell_n^{(0),\mathrm{tr}} = 0$ for $n \geq 3$. Hence $r_{\max}(\mathrm{Heis}_k) = 2$ and $\mathrm{Heis}_k$ is $L_\infty$-formal. Class **G**.

**Example 7.2** (Affine Kac–Moody; class **L**)**.** The affine Kac–Moody vertex algebra $\widehat{\mathfrak{g}}_k$ has $\kappa(\widehat{\mathfrak{g}}_k) = \dim(\mathfrak{g})(k+h^\vee)/(2h^\vee)$. The binary bracket is the Lie bracket on $\mathfrak{g}$; Jacobi kills all degree-four graph contributions, so $\ell_4^{(0),\mathrm{tr}} = 0$, while $\ell_3^{(0),\mathrm{tr}} \neq 0$ in general. Hence $r_{\max}(\widehat{\mathfrak{g}}_k) = 3$. Class **L**.

**Example 7.3** ($\beta\gamma$; class **C**, shadow depth 4)**.** The rank-one bosonic ghost system $\beta\gamma$ has $r_{\max}(\beta\gamma) = 4$: the brackets $\ell_3^{(0),\mathrm{tr}}$ and $\ell_4^{(0),\mathrm{tr}}$ are nonzero, but rank-one rigidity kills degree-five graphs, giving $\ell_n^{(0),\mathrm{tr}} = 0$ for $n \geq 5$. The primary invariants $(p_{\max}, k_{\max}, r_{\max}) = (1, 0, 4)$ are pairwise distinct: simple OPE pole, zero collision depth, shadow depth four. Class **C**.

**Example 7.4** (Virasoro; class **M**, obstructed at every degree)**.** The Virasoro vertex algebra $\mathrm{Vir}_c$ has $\kappa(\mathrm{Vir}_c) = c/2$. The transferred brackets on the primary line of $H^*(\bar{B}(\mathrm{Vir}_c))$ satisfy $m_k^{\mathrm{tr}}(s^{-1}T, \ldots, s^{-1}T) = S_k \cdot e_{2k}$ for $k \geq 2$, with $s^{-1}T$ the desuspension of the conformal vector to bar degree one and $e_{2k}$ the weight-$2k$ basis vector of $\mathrm{Ext}^1$. The first shadow coefficients are

$$S_2 = \tfrac{c}{2}, \qquad S_3 = 2\ (c\text{-independent}), \qquad S_4 = \tfrac{10}{c(5c+22)},$$
$$S_5 = -\tfrac{48}{c^2(5c+22)}, \qquad S_6 = \tfrac{80(45c+193)}{3c^3(5c+22)^2}, \qquad S_7 = -\tfrac{2880(15c+61)}{7c^4(5c+22)^2}.$$

All $S_k$ are nonzero for generic $c$, so $r_{\max}(\mathrm{Vir}_c) = \infty$: Virasoro is intrinsically non-formal. The Maurer–Cartan recursion forces every coefficient to be

nonzero, since the normal-ordered product $:T^n:$ generates operations at every degree. Class $\mathbf{M}$.

*Remark* 7.5 (The four classes exhaust the standard landscape). Classes $\mathbf{G}, \mathbf{L}, \mathbf{C}, \mathbf{M}$ are the only possibilities consistent with the shadow metric identity $H(t)^2 = t^4 Q(t)$ with $\deg Q \leq 2$. A finite depth in $\{5, 6, \dots\}$ would force a higher-degree $Q$, excluded by the algebraicity theorem for the shadow generating function [6]*Thm. on Riccati algebraicity. Depth is therefore 2, 3, 4, or $\infty$, and each is realized.

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Department of Mathematics, Harvard University, Cambridge, MA 02138, USA

*Email address*: `rlorgat@math.harvard.edu`